



Why Your Home Studio Needs a Machete:

8 Secret Steps to the Hyperpop Aesthetic

The 3:00 AM Digital Diary

Clueless about 'Hyperpop'?

Consider this your clinical intervention.

At first glance, the current avant-pop landscape - the so-called "Brat" aesthetic - projects a shivering, 3:00 AM cigarette haze of unrepentant messiness.

To understand contemporary electronic music culture, one must look at the digital architecture built a decade ago by the trailblazing London label PC Music. At the very epicenter of that aesthetic stand Charli XCX, Hannah Diamond and Sophie - between them they prove both pioneer vocalists and visionary users of visual art, whose work has defined an entire micro-genre.

The music they make is frequently filed under

"hyperpop," a hyper-saturated, self-aware evolution of bubblegum pop, dance, and electronic music.

It is a scene that treats commercial tropes with both fierce devotion and ironic distance.

Yet, what makes Hannah Diamond or Chali XCX enduring cult icons is that beneath the glossy veneer, their music achieves a startling, disarming emotional resonance. How does something constructed from pure synthetic machinery feel like a raw diary entry?

It is a performance of nonchalance that sounds like a crumbling club night. However, beneath this neon-green plastic veneer lies a technical Trojan horse.

Sounding this "unprofessional" requires the surgical steel of a master engineer and a degree of technical discipline that borders on the obsessive.

This is *not* accidental noise; it is a meticulously engineered "calculated digital decay" that weaponizes high-gloss precision to simulate chaos. To reach the commercial impact of the elite, we must strip away the haphazard mythos and distil the engineering beneath the veneer. So, let's look inside Hyperpop:



1. *The Art of the Machete*

(Subtractive Arrangement)

The primary shift in contemporary composition is the move from an additive "Rock/Country" model to a subtractive digital framework.

Traditionalists overdub, layering human performances until they achieve a wall of sound. In contrast, the philosophy championed by A.G. Cook and George Daniel treats the DAW like a block of marble.

You do not build a track; you prune it.

Ygin with an over-saturated mass of loops, MIDI blocks, and vocal chops harvested from past recordings, then ruthlessly hack away until only the essential, ear-grabbing minimalist core remains.

"It takes emotional strength to use the delete button assertively. It's painful to work on something and then erase it!" - A. G. Cook.

By working by subtraction, you create a vacuum of silence that makes the remaining transients hit with far more aesthetic violence.

TECH BOX: THE DELETION PROTOCOL

Loop Saturation: Fill your session with dense MIDI blocks and vocal chops until the frequency spectrum is fully saturated.

Scaffolding: Duplicate these blocks across the timeline to create a simple, readable "macro form" (4-bar hook cells and 8-bar contrast blocks).

Muting as a Tool: Do not rely on white noise sweeps for transitions. Create structure by abruptly muting layers to generate "holes" in the arrangement.

Reactivate the Ear: Use these sudden silences to "wrong-foot" the listener's brain, forcing them to re-sync with the track's internal pulse.

2 Auto-Tune as a Confidence Hack

In the avant-pop studio, pitch correction is not a utility for the tone-deaf; it is a psychological lubricant.

Charli XCX characterizes this as a "highly emboldening"

safety net that neutralizes the cold, clinical pressure of the microphone.

By monitoring through real-time Auto-Tune (retune speed 0–8 ms), the singer is freed from the cognitive load of pitch control.

*"I drink and I smoke
and I use Auto-Tune."
- Charli XCX.*

When every note in the headphones is reflected as "perfect," the artist is emboldened to take risks they would avoid in a dry environment - trying exotic melodies, sharp fourths, and uninhibited runs.

It trades traditional precision for a raw, high-energy vibe, turning the performance into an act of ecstatic satire.

3. The "Poke Bass" and the 80s Connection

The physical punch of modern hyperpop low-end is a direct descendant of the 1980s "Precision Pop" movement, specifically

Scritti Politti's David Gamson.

The Sophistipop

Touch: Gamson brought a lineage of obsessive, microscopic pop arrangement to the table. Known for using early digital workstations to pack every micro-moment of the stereo field with intricate percussive synth patches and counterpoint melodies, Gamson's involvement refined the hyperpop blueprint.

The "Poke Bass": A mechanical layering technique designed to ensure the low-end cuts through dense mixes and translates to underpowered iPhone speakers while still shaking the club.

TECH BOX: SOUND DESIGN - THE POKE BASS RECIPE

Layer 1 (The Click): Use an FM synthesizer (Arturia DX7 V or similar). Set a patch with a blisteringly fast percussive attack and zero sustain. This provides the "click" or "poke" that defines the start of the note.

Layer 2 (The Body): Layer a fat, round analog sub-bass (Minimoog or Arturia Mini V) to provide the foundational weight.

The Glue: Group the layers and apply slight compression to fuse the FM "poke" to the analog "thump."

A Grounded

Evolution: On tracks spanning Hannah Diamond's 'Perfect Picture', Gamson helped anchor Diamond's cyber-aesthetic into a more fully realized, widescreen pop reality. The result is a project that retains its futuristic, pristine shine while sounding less

airbrushed and more psychologically grounded than ever before.

4. Mastering with Controlled Damage (Clippers vs. Limiters)

Streaming standards suggest a target of -14 LUFS to preserve dynamics; in the world of avant-pop, this is a

polite suggestion that we violently ignore.

"Commercial Loudness" in high-energy markets resides between -6 and -8 LUFS.

To reach these levels without turning the mix into mush, we favor clippers over limiters.

Limiters use gain reduction that "softens" transients, making them sound dull.

A clipper uses controlled distortion to "brickwall" peaks, preserving the perceived "snap" and transient impact.

TECH BOX: MASTER CHAIN - TRANSPARENCY THROUGH DISTORTION

Hard Clipper (StandardCLIP): Place this first to shave 1.5-3 dB off the highest transients.

CRITICAL: Shut OFF oversampling. The downsampling process "eats" the headroom you just created; keeping it off preserves every decibel of created space.

Limiter (Pro-L2): Apply afterward to handle the sustained body. Because the clipper has pre-shaved the peaks, the limiter won't "pump" or react violently.

The Delta Method: Set the limiter to a 1:1 ratio and engage "Delta" mode. Listen only to what is being removed. If you hear the "body" of the kick or vocals instead of just "crunchy" artifacts, back off.

5. Designing the Uncanny Valley (Formant Shifting)

The "childlike" or "saccharine" persona of Bubble-gum Bass is achieved through Formant Shifting.



You must distinguish between Pitch (fundamental frequency) and Formants (the timbre/tone color defined by the vocal tract).

The Uncanny Valley

Effect: Vocals are heavily treated with

pitch correction, tuning, and micro-editing, yet they are delivered with a childlike, fragile sincerity.

This creates an "uncanny valley" effect. Your brain searches for the human element, and because the vocal tone carries a genuine vulnerability beneath the robotic polish, your empathy fills in the gaps.

Shifting formants independent of pitch allows you to morph a voice's "size" or "gender" while keeping the melody intact, creating an "uncanny" texture that feels both satirical and sincere.

Micro-Proximity:

Rather than drowning the vocal in massive, cavernous reverb to

push it away, production techniques often highlight breath sounds, mouth clicks, and vocal aspirations. Compressed and placed right against the eardrum, it creates an intimate sensation - like someone whispering directly into your ear through a high-end microphone.

6. A. G. Cook Blueprint and Early Sound Design

In the early 2010s, tracks like "Attachment" and "Pink and Blue" established a template shaped primarily by producer and PC Music founder A. G. Cook.

Maximalist Digital

Saturation: Cook utilized pristine, razor-sharp digital synths,

compressed electronic drum machines, and glittering sound effects. Instead of trying to mimic organic instruments (like a real drum kit or an acoustic guitar), the production leaned aggressively into its own artificiality.

The Power of Space:

Despite the maximalist reputation of early hyperpop, these tracks often relied on stark, empty blocks of sound - sparse arpeggios or isolated pads where the vocal floats, completely exposed.

This minimalism forces the listener to confront the melodic and emotional core of the song.

TECH BOX: PATCHING - THE PRÈVE SYNTH TECHNIQUE

Oscillator: Start with a bright Sawtooth waveform for a rich harmonic foundation.

Filter: Select a Formant Filter.

Modulation: e.g. Using serum, employ "NoteOn Rand" in the Matrix to modulate the filter cutoff. This ensures the timbre changes unpredictably with every new MIDI chord.

Signal Path Fix: Crucially, place a 6dB lowpass filter before the distortion module to tame extreme brightness.

Post-Processing: Apply Down-sample distortion for digital aliasing and grit, then use a mix to dial it into a controlled "plastic" texture.

7. Rhythmic Gaslighting and Harmonic Ambiguity

Hyperpop thrives on "wrong-footing" the listener. In "360," we see a masterclass in rhythmic "fake-outs." The track establishes a repetitive pattern but replaces the expected

"anchor note" on the fourth repetition with a "hole" or silence, forcing the brain to re-sync. Harmonically, it denies resolution by flickering between Cmaj, Fmaj, and Am - specifically shifting from B and C (leading tone/tonic) to E and F, then jumping to A.

This "exotic modality" mirrors emotional instability.

The Lydian Lift:

"Sympathy is a Knife" utilizes *E_b* Lydian. The "#4th" (*A[#]*) creates a tense, cinematic rub against the *E_b* foundation.

The Tense Rub:

Listen for the harmonic conflict between the

pedal *B_b* and the *F* chords in the chorus of "Sympathy is a Knife," signalling a protagonist struggling to hold it together.

Digital Artifacts: The "kn-kn-kn-kn-knife" stutter is a deliberate 1/16th note copy-paste edit in Logic, proving that digital errors are now primary expressive tools

TECH BOX: COMPOSING PROCEDURES

Instead of a standard, triumphant pop loop like, (*A -> D -> E -> F[#]*), a longing-infused hyperpop progression might look like this over four bars

{*A_{maj}*} -> {*F[#]_{m7}*} -> {*D_{maj7}*} -> {*E_{sus4}* -> *E*}

Why does this specific sequence pull at your heartstrings?
The Launchpad (*A_{maj}* to *F[#]_{m7}*):

What happens: We start on bright *A_{maj}* but immediately drop into *F[#]_{m7}* (*F*-sharp minor with a suspended 7th, e.g., the notes *F[#] - A - C[#] - E*).

The feeling: Moving from a major chord to a minor-seventh chord instantly pulls the rug out from under pure

happiness.

The minor 7th introduces a bittersweet, breathy quality – it's the sound of a smile fading just a fraction into uncertainty.

The Pivot to Longing (Dmaj7):

What happens: The progression moves to a Major 7th chord on the subdominant (Dmaj7).

The feeling: Major 7th chords are the ultimate cheat code for melancholy in pop music. Because the seventh note of the scale is scraping right against the root note, it creates a subtle, beautiful friction (a dissonance).

It sounds dreamy, suspended in time, and intensely nostalgic—like staring at a phone screen waiting for a text notification that isn't coming.

The Unresolved Tension (Esus4 resolving to E):

What happens: Instead of hitting a solid, comforting resolution, the chord climbs to an Esus4 (suspended fourth) before lazily dropping into a standard Emaj.

The feeling: A suspended chord literally holds its breath; it refuses to commit to being major or minor until the very last millisecond.

By delaying that resolution, it mirrors the agonizing hesitation of unrequited affection – the feeling of wanting to say "I miss you" but holding back.

Note: When inverted once or twice where necessary we severy clever underlying structure in the chord sequence:

Time	Bar 1	Bar 2	Bar 3	Bar 4	Note
Chord	Amaj	F#m7	Dmaj7	Esus4 ->Emaj	
Inv	I	II	III	II	II
-----	-----	-----	-----	-----	-----
Note	F	F#	F#		
Note	C#	C#	C#	G#	G#
Note		E	D	E	E
Note	A	A	A	A	Bb

This gives a fantastic opportunity for a bassline in our key of A dropping a semitone on the last beat of the bar so giving it a powerful, driving feel.

8. Harmonic

Undercurrents and Lyric Writing

The feeling of sincerity in Sophie's or Hannah Diamond's music isn't born from unedited vulnerability; it is a meticulously engineered paradox.

Melancholy

Disguised as Candy:

Rather than sticking to triumphant major-key

pop loops, the underlying chord structures frequently feature suspended chords, minor shifts, and wistful major-seventh intervals. For instance, moving from a bright major root chord into a minor-seventh or major-7th chord introduces a subtle human complexity - smiling through uncertainty or longing

for someone who isn't there.

The Mundane Diary

Entry: Lyrically, the songs bypass sweeping, generic pop clichés in favor of agonizingly modern anxieties: staring at a screen, waiting for an attachment to load, or the specific dread of an unanswered text. Because the words read like raw adolescent text messages, they strip away the cool armor of traditional pop.



The Future of Sincere Satire

So there you have it -
Hyperpop has proven
that "perfect" digital

tools, when weaponized with confidence and a "machete" philosophy, produce the most humanly resonant music of our era.

The studio is no longer a place to capture a performance; it is a compositional tool where "mangled" artifacts are the primary colors of the palette. As technology makes perfection effortless, the question arises, are we now at the point of adding imperfections simply to satisfy the human ear's lust for non-linearities and warmth?

Or can the likes of
Hannah Diamond,
Sophie and Charli XCX
also convince you that
ultimately, technology
and artificiality do not
have to be the enemies
of emotion.



By pushing the synthetic
elements to their
absolute maximum, real
human vulnerability can
cut through the noise,
shining brightly like a
neon sign in the dark
and with harsh, cold,
digital music can still
come intimacy and
sincerity that is
believable, perhaps?



Epilogue:

The author has a severe four-day earworm: Hannah Diamond's "Affirmations". It may be the purest hyperpop ever — painfully pop, irresistibly catchy, glossy, colourful, bright, and transcendent. It is also unusually positive for Hannah Diamond: instead of her usual heart-tugging love themes, it celebrates female empowerment and the simple joy of self-pride. How fantastic!



Keep repeating, keep repeating, keep repeating...